HEALTH & SAFETY

Online Learning Module

Plastering Course — Beginners & Trades

Belfast, Northern Ireland

About This Module

Estimated reading time: 5 minutes

You must complete this module before attending the 3-day in-person training.

This module covers the four key health and safety areas below. Take note — there will be a short quiz at the end.

- Sharp tools & cutting hazards
- Hazardous dust & chemical safety
- Appropriate clothing & hair management
- Personal Protective Equipment (PPE)

Legal Framework (Northern Ireland)

This course follows guidance from the Health & Safety Executive Northern Ireland (HSENI).

- Health & Safety at Work (Northern Ireland) Order 1978
- COSHH Regulations (Northern Ireland) 2003 — Control of Substances Hazardous to Health
- Personal Protective Equipment at Work Regulations (NI) 1993
- Manual Handling Operations Regulations (NI) 1992

As a learner, you have a duty to take reasonable care of your own health and safety and that of others around you.

Section 1 — Working with Sharp Tools

Plastering involves a range of sharp tools including trowels, hawks, corner beads, and scrapers. Cuts and lacerations are among the most common injuries on site — but they are almost entirely preventable.

The Risks

- Deep cuts from trowel edges, especially when cleaning or passing tools to others
- Puncture wounds from metal beads and corner pieces
- Cuts from mixing paddle blades and scrapers during cleaning
- Eye injuries from metal shards or flicked plaster

Safe Practices

DO	DON'T
Always carry tools with blades pointing downward	Never carry a trowel blade facing upward or outward
Pass tools handle-first to another person	Don't throw or slide tools across a surface
Store tools in a proper tool bag or box when not in use	Don't leave tools on the floor or on scaffolding edges
Clean tools carefully, wiping away from the blade	Don't run your fingers along a trowel edge to test sharpness
Wear cut-resistant gloves when handling metal beads	Don't use damaged or cracked tools — report them immediately

First Aid Reminder

If you receive a cut on site, no matter how small, you must:

- Stop work immediately and apply pressure to the wound
- Report the injury to your trainer or supervisor
- Use the first aid kit — location will be shown on Day 1 of your in-person training
- Log the incident in the site accident book

Section 2 — Hazardous Dust & Chemicals

Plastering materials — including cement, gypsum plaster, lime, and finishing compounds — produce fine dust particles and contain chemicals that can cause serious long-term health conditions if not properly controlled.

Health Risks from Dust

- Silica dust (from sand-based renders and cement) can cause silicosis — a permanent, life-limiting lung disease
- Gypsum dust causes respiratory irritation and can aggravate asthma
- Prolonged exposure without protection may lead to occupational asthma
- Fine dust particles penetrate deep into the lungs and are not always visible to the naked eye

COSHH — Control of Substances Hazardous to Health (NI)
Under COSHH Regulations (Northern Ireland) 2003, your employer or training provider must:
• Assess the risk from hazardous substances in the workplace
• Provide adequate ventilation and dust control measures
• Supply appropriate PPE (respiratory protection) free of charge
• Provide information, instruction and training on hazardous substances
YOU must follow all control measures put in place.

Chemical Hazards in Plastering

Material	Key Hazard
Cement / sand render	Silica dust — serious long-term lung disease risk
Gypsum plaster (Thistle, etc.)	Dust irritation, skin dryness, eye irritation
Lime plaster / lime putty	Highly alkaline — causes chemical burns to skin and eyes
Bonding & PVA agents	Skin sensitiser — can cause dermatitis with repeated exposure
Render accelerators / additives	Chemical burns, fumes — always check the product data sheet

Dust & Chemical Safety Rules

- Always read the product data sheet (COSHH sheet) before using any new material
- Ensure the work area is well ventilated — open windows and doors, use fans where possible
- Wet-mix techniques reduce airborne dust — use these where the job allows
- Never dry sweep — use a vacuum with a HEPA filter or damp mopping instead
- Wash hands and face thoroughly before eating, drinking, or going to the toilet
- Apply barrier cream to hands before starting work and moisturiser at the end of the day
- Report any symptoms — coughing, shortness of breath, skin rash — to your trainer immediately

Section 3 — Appropriate Clothing & Hair Management

What you wear on site directly affects your safety. Loose clothing, exposed skin, and unsecured hair all create real risks in a plastering environment — from chemical burns to getting caught in machinery.

What to Wear

Item	Why It Matters
Long-sleeved work shirt or base layer	Protects skin from lime burns, plaster splashes, and sun exposure on outdoor renders
Work trousers (not jeans if possible)	Durable trousers protect knees and legs from abrasion and splashes
Steel-toecap boots (S1P or S3 rated)	Protects feet from dropped tools, heavy bags of plaster and wet mortar
Work socks (not trainer socks)	Prevents blisters and provides ankle support
Close-fitting top layer (no baggy hoodies)	Loose fabric can snag on tools, scaffolding, or get soaked with wet plaster

What NOT to Wear

- No open-toed shoes or trainers — not permitted on any plastering site
- No loose jewellery — rings, bracelets, and necklaces can trap chemicals against skin causing burns
- No shorts — legs must be covered to protect from lime and cement splashes
- No synthetic-only fabric near heat sources — natural or flame-retardant blends are safer

Hair Management

Loose hair is a serious hazard. It can:

- Get pulled into mixing paddle drills causing serious scalp injuries
- Fall into wet plaster, contaminating the work and risking chemical exposure to the scalp
- Obstruct vision when working at height

Hair Rules — Compulsory on This Course
Hair must be tied back and fully secured before entering the practical training area on all 3 days.
• Use a hair tie, braid, or bun — hair must not hang past the collar
• Wear a site cap or skull cap if preferred — this also reduces dust on the scalp
• Beards should be kept tidy and tucked away where possible when wearing a tight-fitting FFP2/FFP3 mask
Learners who arrive without hair secured will be asked to tie it up before starting practical work.

Section 4 — Personal Protective Equipment (PPE)

PPE is your last line of defence when all other safety measures are in place. In plastering, it is not optional — it is a legal requirement. Under the Personal Protective Equipment at Work Regulations (Northern Ireland) 1993, your employer or training provider must supply appropriate PPE, and you must use it correctly.

PPE Required for This Course

PPE Item	When to Use It
Safety glasses / goggles (EN166 rated)	At all times during mixing, application, and grinding. Plaster splashes can cause serious eye damage.
FFP2 or FFP3 dust mask / respirator	Whenever cutting, mixing dry materials, sanding, or working in a dusty environment. Do not use a basic paper mask.
Nitrile gloves	When mixing plaster, handling lime, using PVA or chemical additives. Replace if torn.
Knee pads	When working at floor level — floor screeds, skimming skirting areas. Protects joints from hard floors.
Steel-toecap boots (S1P or higher)	At all times in the practical training space. Non-negotiable.
Hi-vis vest (where required)	On any commercial or external site. Will be required for some in-person training activities.

PPE Golden Rules

- PPE must be worn correctly — goggles pushed up on your head provide zero protection
- Check PPE before each use for damage — cracked goggles, torn gloves, or a crushed mask must be replaced
- Clean PPE after use and store it properly — plaster contamination reduces effectiveness
- Never share respiratory masks — they are fit-tested and personal to you
- Raise it with your trainer immediately if PPE is missing, damaged, or uncomfortable — adjustments can always be made

PPE Compliance — Course Policy
This is our non-negotiable policy for in-person training days:
No PPE = No practical work. This is final and no exceptions will be made.
A PPE pack (goggles, mask, gloves) will be available to purchase on Day 1 if you do not have your own.
If you have any medical condition (e.g. respiratory condition, latex allergy) that affects PPE use, please contact us before the first training day so we can make appropriate arrangements.

Module Summary — Key Points to Remember

Topic	Key Takeaway
Sharp Tools	Always carry blades pointing down. Pass tools handle-first. Store safely. Report damaged tools.
Dust & Chemicals	Silica and lime are serious hazards. Ventilate, wet-mix where possible, never dry sweep. Read COSHH sheets.
Clothing & Hair	Cover all skin. No loose jewellery. Hair must be tied back before entering the practical area.
PPE	Safety glasses + FFP2/3 mask + gloves + steel boots at all times. No PPE = no practical work.

Before You Arrive — Day 1 In-Person Training
Make sure you have read and understood all four sections of this module before attending.
On Day 1 of your in-person training in Belfast, you will sit a short Health & Safety quiz based on the content in this module.
The quiz is 10 questions and you will need 8 out of 10 to pass.
You must pass the quiz before you can take part in any practical plastering work.
• PPE will be provided.
• Contact your trainer before arrival if you have any questions about this module
For H&S advice in Northern Ireland, visit: www.hseni.gov.uk

Stay safe. Look after yourself and those around you.

Good luck with your plastering course!